

A short time later, in 1986, he rubbed a new boss the wrong way and got fired. What to do?

In general, getting fired is probably a lousy way to retire. When you get fired you can lose your self-confidence and feel degraded or humiliated. The last thing you want to do is give up. You want to grab another job and hit back with all you've got. You want to prove that the boss was wrong.

But Lyle is a special case. He has a strong ego. He had prepared himself for retirement. He hadn't achieved his target net worth, even after adding his severance pay. But with a few minor changes in lifestyle he could retire with less.

When Lyle got fired, his wife, Elaine, was a doctor in a Cleveland hospital. She had started her job six months before. She wanted to stick with it for a few years. The original idea had been for Lyle and Elaine to retire together, say in 1990. But when Lyle got fired it ruined their plans.

They decided Lyle would retire and Elaine would keep working. That was in 1986, and so far they're thrilled with the new arrangement. Lyle plays golf, manages their investments, and sits by the pool and reads. He's begun to tackle some of the items his to-do list. With no more business trips, for the first time in their marriage he and Elaine see each other every evening.

Lyle and Elaine believe they're in transition. Lyle may go back to work, at least part time, until Elaine feels ready to quit. Elaine may decide to quit sooner than planned. In the meantime, there's more joy in their lives than ever before.

Maggie is 42, divorced, and has two children living with her ex-husband. She's hyper and high-powered. Before she retired she ran public relations for a Chicago-based engineering company. She enjoyed it but never had time for her true love: architectural history. As a student she used to enjoy travel because it gave her a chance to see new buildings. Each business trip seemed more hurried than the one before.